

SMALL BUSINESS

Competing without a marketing department

The owner of a small shop is expected to post on social media, answer reviews, run ads, and still do the actual job. Big chains have whole teams for that. The owner has ten minutes after closing.

How might we give one local business owner an hour of their day back?

START HERE

Pick a real business you know: a taqueria, a barber, a nail salon, a market. What is the owner doing at 9 PM that is not their real job?

WHERE AI CAN WORK

- Drafting posts, captions, and flyers in the owner's own voice
- Replying to customers and reviews in English and Spanish
- Spotting what sells and suggesting a special

YOU COULD BUILD

- A one-week content kit for your chosen business
- A reply assistant the owner approves with one tap
- A simple advisor that reads a sales sheet and says what to promote

THINK ABOUT (THIS IS SCORED)

No fake reviews and no made-up claims. The owner approves everything before it goes out. Does it still sound like them?

YOUR DAY

- 9:45** Meet your squad. Read this page.
- 10:00** Pick one real person with this problem.
- 10:30** Problem sentence read to your coach.
- 10:30** Build version one.
- 11:45** Lunch
- 12:30** Finish. Make your risks slide.
- 1:10** Stop building. Practice the pitch.
- 1:30** Pitch to your track: 3 minutes.
- 2:15** Finals and awards, Dyer Hall

HOW YOU ARE SCORED

- 25 Problem clarity:** real, specific, belongs to a person
- 25 Use of AI:** AI does real work, not decoration
- 20 Feasibility:** someone could use it and it would matter
- 15 Responsible design:** bias, privacy, who could be harmed
- 15 The pitch:** clear, honest, everyone speaks

Squad name: _____ Who we are building for: _____

YOUR PROBLEM SENTENCE — write it before you build anything

_____ (a real person) struggles with _____
because _____. We will build _____
so they can _____.

YOUR 3-MINUTE PITCH

Meet the person (30 sec). Their problem today (30). What you built and what the AI does, shown live if you can (75). What could go wrong and your safeguard (30). What comes next (15).

RULES

Coaches and mentors help, but never build or present for you. Never type real private information about anyone into an AI tool. Check what the AI tells you; it can be confidently wrong. A working app, a set-up AI assistant, a clickable mockup, or a clear plan with one worked example can all win.

NOTES & SKETCHES

Toolkit links and all six challenges
longbeachaihackathon.org/briefs

